Clinical simulation for student role playing Physiotherapist

Musculoskeletal Physiotherapy – BSc Physiotherapy (Year 2)

Student Role: Physiotherapist

Patient Role: Mr XYZ, 42 years

Primary Complaint: Neck pain and headaches

Patient Scenario

Mr XYZ is a 42-year-old office worker referred to physiotherapy due to ongoing neck pain and frequent headaches.

He:

- Works at a desk for 7–9 hours per day
- Reports gradual onset of neck stiffness and headaches over the past 8 months
- Describes headaches starting at the base of the skull, radiating to the forehead and behind the eyes
- Has been reviewed by a neurologist and prescribed Amitriptyline 10 mg at night for headache management
- Is otherwise medically stable and able to communicate clearly

Your Role as the Physiotherapist

During this 60-minute MSK clinical simulation, you are expected to:

☐ Introduce yourself and gain informed consent
☐ Perform a subjective assessment
☐ Complete a focused objective assessment
☐ Explain your clinical reasoning
☐ Outline an initial management plan

Safety Guidelines

☐ Monitor symptom response throughout
☐ Avoid provoking severe headache or dizziness
☐ Allow rest breaks if symptoms increase
☐ Maintain patient comfort and safety at all times
☐ Prioritise patient safety over performance

1. Introduction & Consent

Student Task

Write 1–2 key points you would include when introducing yourself and explaining the session to the patient.

Notes:

Hints

- Clear professional introduction
- Explain purpose of assessment and treatment
- Reassure the patient and gain consent

2. Subjective Assessment

Student Task

Write at least TWO subjective questions you would ask the patient and document their answers.

Question 1:

Question 1 – Answer:

Question 2:

Question 2 – Answer:

(Optional)

Question 3:

Question 3 – Answer:

Hints to Guide Your Question Choice

Consider asking about:

- Onset and duration of neck pain and headaches
- Headache pattern, intensity, and triggers
- Work setup and postural habits
- Medication use and effectiveness
- Impact on work, sleep, and daily activities

Ask yourself: How will this information guide my objective assessment and treatment plan?

3. Objective Examination

You are now asked to examine the patient.

Safety Rules

- Do not force cervical movements
- Stop assessment if symptoms worsen

- Observe patient response closely

Student Task

Write what you observe, not what you expect to see.

Posture (sitting and standing):

Cervical Range of Motion (ROM):

Muscle tone and tenderness:

Scapular and neck muscle control:

4. Clinical Reasoning

Student Task

Briefly explain why this patient may be experiencing neck pain and headaches.

Explanation:

Hints

- Link prolonged sitting and posture to symptoms
- Identify features of cervicogenic headache
- Consider muscle tension and reduced cervical mobility

5. Initial Management Plan

Student Task

Part A: Treatment Aims

Aim 1:

Aim 2:

Hints

Think about:

- Pain and headache reduction
- Improving cervical mobility
- Postural correction
- Self-management and education

Part B: Treatment Plan

Write and briefly explain 2–3 intervention strategies based on the aims above.